I begin with Dholavira, a Bronze Age metropolis of the Harappan Civilization in the Rann of Kutch, discovered only in 1967. Thriving between 2600–1900 BCE, it is best known for its water harvesting and fine reservoirs. I examine the ancestry of the Harappans, what they excelled at and what distinguishes them from other civilizations of the day—such as not turning up any evidence of temples, wars or armies, and seemingly possessing a flatter social class hierarchy. I consider the languages they likely spoke, their undeciphered script, theories about their demise, and how their legacy lives on today in our lives. I talk to the ecologically vulnerable locals from the nearby village of Dholavira, after which the prehistoric site is named and whose residents too had lived with ecological vulnerability.

After the decline of Harappan cities, Aryan migrants from Central Asia arrived by 1500 BCE and mixed with the locals. A nomadic-pastoralist people, the Aryans brought a proto-Sanskrit language, an early version of the Vedas, new forms of social hierarchy and the horse. After a gap of more than a thousand years since the fall of the Harappan cities, the next cities arose mostly in the Gangetic Plain in the first millennium BCE, moving India from prehistory into the age of decipherable texts, and the time of the Buddha, Mahavira and the early Upanishads. I present some fascinating observations by Megasthenes, Greek ambassador to the Mauryan court in Pataliputra, c. 300 BCE—including a custom where Mauryan men sing and play music to soothe angry elephants. Ashoka's missionary work helped make Buddhism a pan-Asian religion.

I then visit Nagarjunakonda in Andhra Pradesh, a lost world found in 1920. Once called Vijayapuri, it was the capital of the Ikshvaku Kingdom (c. 220–320 CE) that traded with Rome and whose Buddhist institutions were mainly patronized by wealthy women. Among its remains is the only amphitheatre found in ancient India. I take an imaginary walk through the ancient city and consider the ideas of Nagarjuna, founder of the 'Middle Path' school of Mahayana Buddhism—best known for the concept of *shunyata*—and one of the greatest philosophers of all time.

By the mid-first millennium CE, Chinese pilgrims began to arrive on perilous journeys to India. They came seeking Buddhist scholarship and authoritative texts. I present highlights from the surviving records of three of them—Faxian, Xuanzang, Yijing—that provide us vital portraits of Indian social and religious life between 400–700 CE. The 'first and chief